

What is an integral? What is a derivative? What are the applications of these concepts in real life? I can sit in classes at school, waiting eight hours per day until the bell rings, listening to my teachers ramble, deriving formulas for how to remove the “xy term” from an equation and how to rotate a two dimensional figure in the equation that defines it. But no matter how long I sit there, I’m not getting the quality education found in the hands-on learning that VEX provides. Don’t get me wrong – math can be a useful tool in life. But it’s only because of VEX that I *understand* where I can use it. You could sit Pythagoras himself down in front of me (well, when he was alive – I doubt this would work too well today) and have him explain over and over that “ $a^2 + b^2 = c^2$ ”, but I wouldn’t remember a darn thing about it until I get to build the triangle myself.

Now, where’s this education gonna take you? Well... Um... Where *won’t* it take you? My brother has a *job* already because of his robotics experience. My teammates who have graduated are going to prestigious colleges, and all of them are majoring in robotics-related fields. And me? This is my fourth year as the captain of my team. My future looks bright because VEX has given me a solid foundation by showing me how to apply concepts from school in real life.